



The 1932 Revolution as a Critical Juncture: Constitutional Monarchy and Dual Institutions

CHAPTER TWO

POLITICS AND GOVERNMENT
OF THAILAND

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I

The 1932 Revolution and the End of Absolute Monarchy



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- A decisive turning point in Thailand's political history occurred on 24 June 1932 when the *Khana Ratsadon* ("People's Party")—a group of 99 army officers, navy officers, and mid-level civil servants—staged a coup against King Prajadhipok (Rama VII).
 - While the King resided at Klai Kangwon Palace in Hua Hin, the People's Party mobilized troops in Bangkok, assembled battalions at the Royal Plaza, read a declaration announcing the end of absolute monarchy, and detained senior royals and government military leaders at the Ananta Samakhom Throne Hall. The Party then invited King Prajadhipok to return to Bangkok.

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- Their aim was to abolish absolute monarchy and inaugurate a democratic regime.
 - King Prajadhipok accepted to remain as head of state, and later that year granted the Temporary Charter of the Administration of Siam, B.E. 2475 (1932)—the country's first constitution.

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- Yet the People's Party consolidated its position by making itself guardian of the new order.
 - Under the Charter, it held sovereign power through a military committee and appointed seventy temporary members of the House of Representatives until elections could be held.
 - The Party also secured control of the armed forces by placing its own members in command: Phraya Phahon Phonphayuhasena as Army Commander, Phraya Songsuradet as Deputy Army Commander and Director of Operations, Phraya Ritthi Akhaney as Commander of Artillery, and Luang Phibunsongkhram as Deputy Commander of Artillery.

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- The permanent constitution promulgated in December 1932 created a unicameral legislature divided equally between indirectly elected members and members appointed by the King.
 - Political parties were prohibited.
 - This arrangement, which blended parliamentary institutions with the old elite's continuing power, ensured that appointed representatives remained dominant in government formation.

II

The Origin of the Militarization of Politics

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- The first years of constitutionalism were turbulent. The inaugural Prime Minister, Phraya Manopakorn Nititada, a respected Supreme Court judge, headed three successive cabinets in 1932–1933. His second government collapsed after only four months over fierce disputes regarding Pridi Banomyong's *National Economic Plan*.
 - Manopakorn's faction denounced the plan as socialist and impractical for a largely unprepared population, and accused Pridi's supporters of communism. The confrontation deepened in Parliament, where debates grew so heated that MPs were searched for weapons before entering sessions.

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- In April 1933, Manopakorn dissolved Parliament and formed a third government, but by June the political crisis escalated when four prominent People's Party military leaders—Phraya Phahon, Phraya Songsuradet, Phraya Ritthi Akhaney, and Phraya Prasart Phitthayakhun—resigned from their posts. Their unexplained departure provoked public protests, particularly from tramway workers, then a powerful labor force.
 - This tension culminated in the **coup of 20 June 1933**, when Phraya Phahon, with Phibunsongkhram and Luang Suphachalasai, ousted Manopakorn and became Prime Minister. This was Thailand's first coup under constitutional government, marking the end of attempts to compromise with the old elites.

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- The People's Party's control was soon tested by a royalist counter-revolt. On 11 October 1933, Prince Boworadet led a military uprising against the government, citing discontent with its policies. The rebellion escalated into a bloody civil conflict, the first armed clash under the new democratic system. Ultimately, government forces under Phraya Phahon prevailed, but the rebellion caused heavy casualties among soldiers and civilians alike.
 - The rebellion's suppression demonstrated both the fragility and resilience of the nascent constitutional regime. It enabled the People's Party to press ahead with the scheduled election of 15 November 1933—the first (and only) indirect parliamentary election in Thai history. With 1.77 million voters (41.45% turnout), seventy-eight MPs were elected, among them future political leaders such as Liang Chaikarn and Thong-in Phuriphat. Phraya Phahon remained Prime Minister, this time as head of the first truly parliamentary government.

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- After repeated cabinet reshuffles, Phraya Phahon resigned in 1937 and again in 1938, but was twice returned as Prime Minister. By 1938, however, the balance of power shifted decisively when Colonel Plaek Phibunsongkhram (later Field Marshal Phibun) was chosen Prime Minister. His premiership inaugurated **the era of military dominance**.
 - During his first term, Phibun elevated his rank to Field Marshal and, under wartime conditions, consolidated power. His government introduced sweeping nationalist reforms, centralized authority, and aligned the state with Axis powers during World War II. In 1944, however, Parliament forced his resignation after rejecting decrees on relocating the capital to Phetchabun and constructing a Buddhist metropolis, signaling resistance to authoritarian overreach.

III

Post-War Transitions and the End of the People's Party Legacy



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- After Phibun's fall, Khuang Aphaiwong briefly became Prime Minister in 1944, followed by Pridi Banomyong in 1946. Pridi's tenure was overshadowed by the mysterious death of King Ananda Mahidol, for which his government faced harsh criticism and accusations of concealment. He resigned in August 1946, citing poor health and political exhaustion. His ally, Thawan Thamrongnawasawat, succeeded him but lasted less than a year.
 - By 1947, the fragile civilian governments faced mounting pressure from conservative and military factions, paving the way for another rupture.

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- On 9 November 1947, General Phin Choonhavan led a coup that toppled Thawan's government. This marked the return of military and royalist-conservative dominance. The 1946 Constitution was abrogated and replaced with the *Interim Constitution of 1947*, which greatly expanded royal prerogatives. The “Council of Regency” and “Supreme Council of State,” reminiscent of pre-1932 institutions, were revived.
 - Khuang Aphaiwong was installed as Prime Minister, but his cabinet was heavily populated with princes and aristocrats—an unprecedented royalist comeback since the 1932 revolution. Elections held under military oversight in 1948, 1949, 1952, and 1957 were widely regarded as instruments of legitimation rather than genuine democratic contests.

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- By the 1950s, Field Marshal Phibun had returned to power, but his regime lost legitimacy after the “**dirty election**” of **26 February 1957**, which provoked mass protests in Bangkok.
 - General Sarit Thanarat, then a rising military leader, distanced himself from Phibun and ultimately staged a coup on 16 September 1957.



Recommended Further Readings

- Baker, Chris, Christopher John Baker, and Pasuk Phongpaichit. *A History of Thailand*. Cambridge University Press, 2022.
- Morell, David, and Chai-Anan Samudavanija. *Political Conflict in Thailand: Reform, Reaction, Revolution*. Cambridge, MA: Oelgeschlager, Gunn & Hain, 1981.
- Neher, Clark. *Democracy and development in Southeast Asia: the winds of change*. Routledge, 2018.